CHAPTER VI

THE BRIDGE OF CHRIST

Alexander had shifted the Hellenic center of gravity right out of Greece itself. And for some generations after his death it stood at Alexandria, where General Ptolemy proved the strongest among Alexander's successors. His slice of the empire grew to include Libya to the west, Palestine to the east, and the island of Cyprus in the north.

The delta seacoast is low in profile and its waters are treacherously shallow. To overcome this drawback and make Alexandria the world's most important harbor, Ptolemy Soter ("Savior" as he now styled himself) built a lighthouse. This creation soon became, like the Hanging Gardens of Babylon, an object of wonder to travelers the world over. It was reputed to be four hundred feet in height. The illumination provided by the tall flaming wicks of its oil lamps was magnified and beamed far out to sea by means of reflecting mirrors. Greek science came together with Greek adventurousness in that monument. It was a practical thing, of course, but also a symbol of the ancient impulse which had drawn legendary Odysseus over the seas to the underworld and home again.

The world's first museum, or "home of the muses," was Ptolemy

Pyrrhus, king of Epirus and winner of a costly victory over Rome

Soter's second great contribution to civilization. In the beginning, he modeled it upon the Athenian Lyceum founded by Alexander's teacher, Aristotle. But that had been a relatively tiny and private institution whereas this one was immense and supported by Ptolemy's own almost bottomless tax resources.

Blessed with invariable sunshine, Egypt's fields were enriched each year by brown silt brought down upon the back of generous Nile. The great river was to prove faithful in this way for more than two thousand years to come. (Not until our own time was its nourishing force transposed to a different dimension, namely electric power, by the building of the Aswan Dam.) In classical times, Alexandria was the funnel for a major portion of the world's grain. Greece, which has so little arable land, obtained her bread chiefly from Egypt and only secondarily from Greek colonies along the Black Sea coast in southern Russia. All this being true, Ptolemy held in his fist at Alexandria an exceedingly rich and unfailing revenue. It enabled him to overshadow Alexander's other heirs in the military sense and at the same time to devote Alexandria to cultural pursuits. Alexandria never had anything like the spirit and creative drive of Athens in the age of Pericles, but she was vastly richer and more stable than her cultural ancestor.

At Alexandria the time of the textbook began. The museum there was the world's Oxford University, Ford Foundation, and Rand Corporation all rolled into one. Its highest functionary, traditionally, was a literary man. But at Alexandria the profession of literature ceased to be inspired. Grammarians took over. They laid down rules for such things as spelling and the use of accents. Those rules very soon assumed an importance quite out of proportion to their usefulness, which obtains to this day. As an example of the donnish dryness which threatened to bury Greek culture while presuming to preserve it, here is a communication from King Philadelphus (Ptolemy II) to the scholar Sosibius, who had complained that his salary was late in coming. "The first syllable of your name," the king replied, "occurs in Soter. The second occurs in Sosigenes, the third in Bion and the fourth in Apollonius. Since I have paid all four of those gentlemen, you may consider that you also have received your fee."

Government-sponsored scholarship and research exhibited the same strengths and the same drawbacks which it has today. As in the United

States and the Soviet Union now, Alexandrian scientists found themselves showered with funds but at the same time called upon to pursue nonhumanitarian lines of investigation. The affair of Queen Berenice's Hair may be taken as a case in point. Berenice, the wife of Ptolemy III, dedicated a lock of her hair in an Alexandrian temple. Unaccountably, it disappeared. The palace ordered the museum to get up a full report on the case. After a great deal of diligent digging and pondering in committee, the museum returned its verdict in verse form. Its conclusion was that Berenice's Hair had been translated to heaven as a constellation—which carries her name even now.

When Berenice's little daughter died, the palace decreed a leap year in her honor, to recur at regular four-year intervals. This brought solar and lunar calendars into harmony at long last. Once learned, the lesson was not forgotten. Our own "Julian" calendar is the Alexandrian one, which Julius Caesar saw fit to impose upon the world.

The work of the museum might be frivolous, as in the little business of Berenice's Hair, or practical, as in the institution of leap year. Then, too, it might be "pure" in the modern scientific sense of that term. Aristarchus of Samos was a museum member whose thoughts ranged very far. He submitted a paper to the Ptolemies arguing that the earth revolves around the sun. This paper apparently failed to convince them. The world was going to have to wait until the Renaissance to learn from the lips of Copernicus what Aristarchus had already guessed.

Eratosthenes held the museum's chief post—that of librarian—in Aristarchus' time. He used his intellectual and administrative powers to produce the world's first comprehensive geography. His maps were limited by the primitive state of exploration in his time, but they fitted the facts then known. There was nothing wishful or fabulous about Eratosthenes' map making. Yet he exercised the boldness of speculative science at its best. His greatest achievement had to do with measurement. At midday in midsummer at Alexandria, the sun casts a shadow of seven and a half degrees, or one fiftieth of a complete circle. Five hundred miles up the Nile, at Aswan, the sun casts no shadow at all during that singular midsummer moment. Therefore, said Eratosthenes, the earth must be fifty times five hundred miles (or 25,000 miles) around. He then proceeded to calculate the planet's diameter at 7,850 miles—a scant seventy-five miles off the true figure.

Such calculations were made possible by the greatest museum man of them all, Euclid. He dared tell a Ptolemy that "there is no royal road to geometry." The king seems to have taken this assertion in good part, but schoolchildren ever since have had cause to shudder at its grim truth. Euclid's *Elements* remained the mathematician's Bible until just the other day. In terrestrial conditions and at ordinary speeds it still works perfectly. Only deep space conditions and added dimensions put a wobble in Euclid's monument of the mind.

Now, let us come out of the museum and leave Egypt altogether. The year is 280 B.C., and mainland Greece stands once again under terrible threat. Two centuries previous, in the year 480, Xerxes had led his vast Asiatic host down upon Greece. The steadfastness of a Leonidas, the mother-wit of a Themistocles, and seeming miracles as well, were needed to hurl Xerxes back. This time the danger appeared just as great. Barbarian hordes of Gauls from the Danube region were marching through the mountains into Macedon. The country which had given birth to Alexander and his invincible spearmen was crumpling under the weight of barbarian battle-axes. The city-states of central Greece and the Peloponnesus banded together to try to stop the onrush of the Gallic host at Thermopylae. Brennus, the Gallic king, like Xerxes before him, detoured around the pass. But he did not bother to turn and destroy Thermopylae's defenders as Xerxes had done. Instead, he plunged straight on toward Delphi with his huge host. The allied Greek armies disbanded, because resistance appeared useless. Each city-state hoped privately to wait out and perhaps escape the Gallic sweep.

Brennus had heard that Delphi was filled with votive offerings of gold. Like Alexander bearing down upon Persian Persepolis with its treasury of gold bullion, Brennus came on fast. The priests at Delphi begged the god Apollo for some word. "What should we do?" they asked the oracle. A scorched-earth policy had been proposed by some. If the barbarians found no food and wine to sustain their advance, perhaps they might turn back. Such was the forlorn hope of the Greeks. They began removing their stores to mountain caves. But, strangely enough, the god vetoed this course. Let the barbarians come, the oracle commanded in Apollo's name. "The care for these things falls on me and the white maidens."

The only weakness of the fur-clad Gallic horde was its indiscipline.

A section from an Alexandrian astronomical treatise, written on papyrus, demonstrates the movements of the planets.

Brennus' army advanced raggedly. Contingents kept splitting off from the main body to pillage farms and villages along the way. Such detours would end with orgies of feasting and drunkenness, which put the horde in further disarray. Meanwhile a few thousand Greek warriors—no more than that—elected to help Apollo defend his sanctuary. Heroically, they stood up to King Brennus' initial attack along the Sacred Way. The earth quaked, according to contemporary accounts, and at the height of the battle Zeus rained thunderbolts upon the enemy. The priests of the shrine were shouting that they could see Apollo himself leading the fight and that they heard the twanging of his silver bow. One thing certain is that King Brennus was successfully beaten back. Perhaps only the vanguard of his horde had taken part.

At any rate, Brennus retired for the night and camped with all his hundreds of thousands in the deep gorge below the shrine. Then came the "white maidens" mentioned in Apollo's prophecy. The snow fell more and more thickly. Howling winds swept it into drifts around the sleeping Gauls. They woke up shivering. The dawn seemed only a lighter darkness to them. The whirling silent snow still fell blindingly upon them, blocking the gorge where they stood. Trying to climb up out of it toward the sanctuary, they slipped and fell. Clutching their battle-axes, they rolled down the slope. The Greek defenders of the shrine came after them, on the attack. Bewildered, the barbarians broke and ran this way and that. They called to one another through the snow, but soon lost touch. In small groups they wandered the frigid flank of Apollo's mountain. The villagers whose houses they had burned now appeared out of the snow with sharp pitchforks and pruning hooks. The Gauls ran, slipping and sliding, until struck down. Brennus himself was severely wounded. His bodyguard carried him on his shield down to a valley filled with sunshine, and then northward again toward home. Of the whole horde, perhaps a third got out of Greece alive. The god Apollo had been vindicated. At the same time, a new alarm had been sounded. From this point onward, for a thousand years and more, the main threats to civilization would spring from the fields and forests of the barbarian north.

Pyrrhus, a cousin of Alexander the Great, had inherited the northwesterly corner of Alexander's empire; namely, rugged Epirus along the coast of what is now Albania. Pyrrhus was a brilliant general, by all

accounts. His mountain troops were hard-bitten men. He might conceivably have stood up to the barbarian horde, but during the year 280 B.C., Pyrrhus was away in southern Italy. His purpose there was to save the city-states of Magna Grecia from the swelling power of republican Rome. Pyrrhus hoped that in so doing he could also carve out an overseas empire for himself with Tarantum (modern Taranto under the heel of the Italian boot) as its capital. The Romans had more reserves of manpower, by far, than Pyrrhus could command. He thought to overcome them by superior tactics and discipline. He brought war elephants along to overawe the Roman cavalry. But when Pyrrhus first looked down from a spur of the Apennines upon an armed camp of the Romans, he was appalled. There was nothing barbarous, he saw, about those four-square fortifications and those heavily armored troops drilling in the hot sun below. Pyrrhus did manage to win his first battles against the Romans, but only at an insupportable cost in blood. "One more such victory," he groaned, "and we are lost." The phrase "a Pyrrhic victory" passed into literature from that complaint. He retreated at last to the Epirus, in northwestern Greece, remarking that he was leaving a marvelous battlefield to Rome and Carthage.

Pyrrhus proved right. The Greek city-states of southern Italy and Sicily were swallowed up in the long Punic Wars between Rome and Carthage. Macedon joined the losing side in that struggle, and suffered severe defeat at Roman hands. Sparta, however, had made an alliance with the Roman Republic. The ancient Spartan ideals and the new Roman ones were not, after all, so far apart.

In times gone by, Greek intellectuals often had been impressed and even seduced by the puritanical virtues of Sparta. Now, in the same way, some of them were drawn to Rome. The historian Polybius first entered Rome as a Greek hostage, but he stayed to become the Republic's best political apologist and a tutor to Scipio Africanus. "To my thinking," Polybius wrote, "the greatest difference between the Roman Constitution and all others is in the sphere of religion. Everywhere else, religious feeling is regarded as superstition and a matter for reproach, but here it is the mortar which binds the whole state together." But, he concluded, Rome also was sure to degenerate in the course of time.

Polybius watched the burning of Carthage at Scipio's side. By the light of the blaze, he saw that tears were streaking the Roman victor's

cheeks. "Why do you weep?" he asked. Scipio replied with two lines from Homer's *Iliad*:

> *The day will come when holy Troy shall be destroyed,*
> *And Priam of the mighty spear, and Priam's tribe.*

The implication was obvious. Troy had risen and gone. So had the power of Nineveh and Babylon. Persia had flourished, only to see power fade away. In days gone by, Xerxes, the Persian Great King, had wept to realize the fact that his own generation of men was doomed to perish utterly. Greece, led by Alexander of Macedon, also had reigned far and wide. Alexander, according to legend, wept upon the banks of the Indus River to think that he had no more worlds to conquer. Now Greek strength, too, lay crumbled into bits. As for Carthage, the great African city blazed merrily. Scipio wept for his defeated enemy because he had the vision to foresee Rome's own ultimate doom.

As for Greece, that land was already finished as a Mediterranean power. Her role in history had passed from the positive to the negative role. However, this shift was not acknowledged publicly until the year 196 B.C., when a Roman proconsul named Flamininus made it official.

A Germanic medallion depicting a mounted warrior

In that year, at the Isthmian Games (athletic contests sponsored by Corinth), Flamininus arose to declare that henceforward Rome would act as the divinely appointed "Protector" of Greece. Some members of his audience sat stunned, while others cheered, and still more sighed with sad relief.

Half a century later, Greece took part in an ill-starred Asiatic revolt against Roman oppression. The response was crushing. To set a clear example to the rest of the country, as the Romans self-righteously explained, rich Corinth was leveled to the ground. Lucius Mummius, the Roman general in charge of that operation, took pains to have the sacred statuary of Corinth crated up for shipment to Rome. The shipments were insured, and Mummius insisted that if any works of art were lost in transit they should be replaced by others "just as good." The sensibilities of people in command seldom kept pace with their terrible power. It never occurred to Mummius that carvings by such gentle masters as Phidias and Praxiteles can never be replaced. He turned central Greece and the Peloponnesus into a minor dependency known as the Province of Achaea.

Greece served as a battleground for Julius Caesar and Pompey in

An early Christian adaptation of the crucifix combining Christ's monogram with an alpha and omega, symbolizing the beginning and end

Rome's first civil war, but that is no part of our story. Caesar's affair with Cleopatra has, however, some little pertinence. She was the last of the royal line founded at Alexandria by General Ptolemy. Brilliant as well as beautiful, and fully royal in spirit, she recalls Alexander's mother, Queen Olympias of Epirus. When Julius Caesar's assassination shattered Cleopatra's power base within the Roman government, she recouped by seducing his avenger, Mark Antony. A naval battle in Greek waters off Actium won the Roman Empire for a new Caesar, Augustus. He was too cold a man for Cleopatra ever to seduce. At age thirty-four, with Antony gone and possibly her own beauty fading, she killed herself. Augustus thereafter ruled that Roman officers should not so much as visit Alexandria without his own express permission. Egypt was too corrupting, the emperor explained.

Augustus was a hard and unappealing man, but he imposed the Peace of Rome from the Rhine and the Danube down to the Sahara, and from Britain all the way to Babylon. Then, at that rare moment of world calm, the Prince of Peace was born.

The common tongue of the eastern Mediterranean was Greek. Jesus spoke to His disciples in Aramaic, of course, but when He addressed Pontius Pilate and the like He, too, must have spoken in Greek. The four Apostles wrote their Gospels in Greek. One of their number, John, was evidently steeped in Greek philosophy. "In the beginning was the Word," he writes, and that assertion instantly reconciles Platonic thought to the experience of the Hebrew prophets.

In Jesus' time, the Jews of the Dispersion already numbered seven million, by some estimates. They spoke the tongues of the countries into which they were born, Greek being the commonest. The Jews of Alexandria preached the Old Testament—the Septuagint—in Greek. Hebrew synagogues stood scattered from one end of the classical world to the other, and they were hospitable. Many Gentiles found themselves drawn away from the proliferation of pagan cults and magical practices to the monotheism and moral rigor of the Jewish faith. Even without undergoing circumcision, these semiconverts were accepted by the Jews as "Fearers of the Lord."

All this helps explain the fact that Jesus' disciples and the Apostle Paul were able to spread the "good news" of Christ's incarnation, death, and subsequent resurrection so successfully. Within a scant three

decades they converted a significant portion of the common people of the Roman Empire to Christianity. But there are still further reasons back of this phenomenon which bear specifically upon the cultural history of Greece. For a long time before the coming of Jesus, it appears, Greek thinkers and doers had helped prepare a bridge for Him.

Alexander the Great had been among the first of these. As Plutarch later wrote, Alexander did not "treat the Greeks as if he were their leader and the barbarians as if he were their master. He did not cultivate the Greeks as friends and relations while behaving to the barbarians as if they were animals or plants. He believed that he had a mission from God to bring men into harmony with each other and to reconcile the world." This seems extravagant praise, perhaps, for a man of the sword. But Plutarch expressed the opinion most commonly held concerning Alexander's deepest motivation. When the Conqueror emerged from his tent and cried out to his troops, "But you are all my kinsmen!" he meant it. His army, which responded to the cry with an immediate hymn of victory, believed Alexander's implied assertion of the brotherhood of man.

Among philosophers, Socrates in particular helped prepare the way for Christianity. To many Greeks, his martyrdom appeared in retrospect as a foreshadowing of Jesus' own.

Socratic simplicity of life style was adopted by many of his followers, none more extreme perhaps than the "cynic" Diogenes. Cynic means "dog-like" in Greek. Diogenes earned this epithet by living like a stray dog on the streets. Alexander himself once met Diogenes and asked what he could do for him. "You're standing in my sunlight," the sage replied. "Move over." The Conqueror, retreating, told his friends that if he were not himself he would like to be Diogenes. Rough though he was in manner and conversation alike, Diogenes also stood for the brotherhood of man. Asked where he hailed from, he replied, "I am a cosmopolitan." He meant the same thing as the American philosopher of revolution, Tom Paine, who said, "the world is my country."

The founder of the Stoic school at Athens, whose name was Zeno, worked out the logical conclusions of such sentiments. He held, according to Plutarch, "that we should regard all men as fellow-parishioners and fellow-citizens. There ought to be one way of life and one system of order, as it were of one flock on a common pasture feeding

all together under a common law." The relevance of this pre-Christian doctrine to the teachings of Jesus and His disciples is obvious. In the brotherhood of Christ, as Saint Paul put the case, was "neither Greek nor Jew . . . Barbarian, Scythian, bond, nor free." Final union of the children of God would obliterate all such dichotomies, including the most grievous split of all, which was between slaves and free people. Slavery was of course the worst great curse of the classical world. Here is the place to look at it in more detail, since slaves made particularly strong recruits to Christianity.

Socrates was once offered a gift of slaves from a rich friend. He refused them. Virtue, Socrates understood, was no class privilege. "Stop to think," he cautioned his friends, "whether it is your slave or yourself who deserves a whipping." Moreover, he once coaxed a geometrical theorem from an illiterate slave boy in order to prove that wisdom is inborn in everyone.

Plato was less clear, perhaps, on that difficult point. His chief political dialogues, the *Republic* and the *Laws*, are rigidly authoritarian. In the ideal state envisioned by him, only philosophers were free. He thought that those philosophers would be members of the Establishment. The sad fact is that Socrates, who championed free critical inquiry, would hardly have survived a day in Plato's heavenly city. Yet at the same time Plato does seem to have possessed some dim vision of what Jesus was to mean when He said: "Consider the lilies of the field. . . ." God alone, Plato wrote, "is worthy of supreme seriousness. But man is God's plaything, and that is the best part of him. Therefore every man and woman should live life accordingly, and play the noblest games, and be of another mind from what they are at present. For example, people ought not to take war seriously. In war there is neither play nor education worthy of the name."

Rather ruefully, in his turn, Aristotle noted that the leisure required to make room for play and for education depended upon the institution of slavery. He himself kept slaves, although Aristotle set an important precedent by freeing them in his will. He was a pioneer of science, but naturally Aristotle never guessed that science itself would one day render human slavery obsolete.

We tend to picture the slaves of the classical world as having been worked to death under the lash. That did happen, of course. The condi-

An early Christian ivory represents Mary and other mourners at Christ's sepulcher, while He is shown, above, ascending into Heaven.

tions of slave labor in the Athenian silver mines near Sounion—to offer a single example—were notorious. As a rule, however, efficiency and economy demanded that slaves be rather carefully treated. House slaves did more than fetch and carry; they often served as governesses and tutors to the children. They, in particular, therefore, were fitted both to learn and to teach the new Christian dispensation. So, too, were the "organization men" of the Greek and Roman mercantile economy. The middle and lower echelons of business in the time of Christ were very largely filled by slaves. It should be noticed in passing that the biggest business of all was slavery itself. The sacred island of Delos had been transformed into an entrepôt for the eastern Mediterranean slave market. At peak seasons on that tiny and lovely island, ten thousand human beings were bought and sold every day. The Greco-Roman villas with their beautiful mosaic floors which may still be seen at Delos belonged to slave merchants.

"As I would not wish to be a slave, I would not wish to be a master either." That was the position of the Stoics, according to Diogenes Laertius. With Zeno and his followers, Greek philosophy arrived at the same views which were to be expressed in the distant future by Abraham Lincoln. So thoughtful slaveowners, too, were now prepared in their own minds for the revolutionary message of Jesus.

What about woman's position? It was hardly superior to that of slaves. Even glorious Pericles, who owed so much to his lady Aspasia, advised the women of Athens that they should keep and cherish personal obscurity. A Hellenistic treatise written at Alexandria and called *The Questions of Ptolemy* warned: "Remember, O King, that womankind is headstrong, hot in the pursuit of its own wishes, apt to change readily for want of sound reasoning, and naturally weak. For these reasons, women should be prudently handled. One had best not quarrel with them."

So much for the supercilious Greek view. Jewish men, unhappily, went so far as to thank God in their prayers that they had not been born female. Yet Judaism seems to have been particularly appealing to Gentile women. Josephus, the ancient Jewish historian, reported, "Many Greeks have come over to our Laws." The women of Damascus, he added, were "addicted to the Jewish religion." Nero's empress, Poppaea, was said to be a secret sympathizer with the Jews. These conver-

The apostles Peter and Paul, portrayed in a stone bas-relief

sions probably occurred because, for all the flat paternalism of their faith, the Jews possessed a deep sense of social justice—which women in particular could appreciate. This was to be the case with Christianity as well. Moreover, women especially understood the tender relation of Jesus to the three Marys. For them to welcome the new dispensation was only natural.

When active and worldly force falls to dust, the invisible power of passive transformation may reach its apogee. So it was with Greece in the time of Christ. Greece had nurtured a very profound, far-reaching pagan faith which centered upon Delphi. Again, Greece had given birth to Western philosophy, and with it the hope of discovering truth. Faith and Hope, then, were hers. Charity, or love, Greece had not yet achieved. That comes by inspiration, from without, and the Apostle Paul was the man who brought it to Greece. The story of how he did so is told in the *Acts of the Apostles,* which Luke, his companion, wrote. Saint Luke himself appears to have been Greek. Luke's account of their adventures gives a vivid picture of everyday Greek life. It describes

extremely modest events and victories. Yet Paul's experiences as a preacher were to prove even more momentous in the long run than the exploits of Alexander the Great.

Paul was a Hellenized Jew, a native of Asia Minor, and honorary citizen of Rome. His mission on behalf of Christ brought him and Luke to the site of ancient Troy, where Achilles, Xerxes, and Alexander had once sacrificed to pagan gods and sworn to do great deeds. As for Paul, he lay down, simply, and dreamed a dream. It seemed to him that a Macedonian spearman stood over his bed, saying: "Come across into Macedonia and help us." That was all there was to it. "When Paul had this vision," Saint Luke reports, "we immediately made ready to go to Macedon, since God had called us to preach the Gospel there."

They settled in the town of Philippi, which had no synagogue. Paul used to preach on the riverbank outside the city gate. He was much annoyed by a slave girl who kept crying, "These men can tell you how to save your souls!" Paul learned that the girl was gifted with second sight, and that her owners had become rich by hiring out her services as a fortuneteller. Doubtless this circumstance angered him yet further. Turning to face the wild-eyed girl, he commanded the spirit of prophecy to go away and leave her in peace. Instantly, the girl was calm. As she no longer prophesied, her owners accused Paul of destroying their source of income. The Apostle was hustled off to jail, flogged, and left with his feet clamped in stocks. Some other prisoners were in the cell with him. Paul preached, and prayed, and sang hymns. At midnight, the jail suddenly shook. The prisoners' fetters fell from the walls. The doors flew open. The jailer, in his guardroom, drew a sword to kill himself. He preferred that fate to the slow death which would be his punishment for letting the prisoners escape. Paul, however, glimpsed the jailer's action through the door. He shouted at once: "Don't harm yourself! We are all here." The jailer called for lights, entered Paul's cell, fell on his knees, and asked, "What must I do in order to be saved?" So Paul had a new convert to show for his own brief suffering and the midnight act of God. In the morning he was released with suitable apologies. The magistrates would not have had Paul flogged, they said, if they had known he was a citizen of Rome.

Moving on through Amphipolis, Apollonia, and Thessalonike, Paul reached Athens. The ancient town was shrunken inside of its volumi-

This sixth-century icon illustrating scenes from the gospel was originally the lid of a Byzantine reliquary.

nous walls. There was still a great deal of sacred statuary, however. The beauty of those things, Paul could not see. He went down to the market place and began preaching against idolatry. As a result, he was summoned before the Areopagus, Athens' oldest court, to answer the charge of propagating outlandish deities. This was not considered too grave an offense because, as Luke explains, "Athenians liked nothing so much as gossiping about the latest novelty." Paul used the occasion to deliver a sermon. Socrates, long before him, had done much the same thing. But times were easier now that Athens had become a half-ruined backwater. Nothing seemed to matter so much any more. Smiling and yawning behind their hands, the council members listened tolerantly as Paul proclaimed: "I have perambulated Athens and the Acropolis to gaze upon your objects of worship. Among the altars I have seen was one which bore an inscription saying, *To the Unknown God.* That deity, which you worship in ignorance, I can make known to you." Paul went on to speak of Christ's resurrection from the dead. At that point, he was interrupted by general laughter. The council dismissed him, without a reprimand.

It is much easier to convert a sinner than a theologian. Teachers, often enough, are the last to be taught. It may have been for these reasons that Paul soon abandoned Athens for Corinth, where he settled down. Corinth had risen from its ashes to become a notorious port of call for pleasure seekers and a sailors' town. Its temple of Aphrodite boasted a thousand priestess-prostitutes of renowned charms.

Like every mercantile center on the Mediterranean, Corinth also had its Jewish community. The Jews of Corinth were hospitable to Paul at first, but his teaching shocked most of them. Barred from the synagogue, he swore: "Let this be on your heads. I shall preach to the Gentiles, in any case." In a dream, Jesus comforted him and promised that he would come to no harm from the people of Corinth. So Paul stayed on for eighteen months. While at Corinth, he managed to set up the nucleus of a Christian community. That done, he set sail for Ionia. His missionary journeys were to carry him to Jerusalem and westward again all the way to Rome.

Paul's first letter back to the Christian community at Corinth bears quoting at length. This epistle stands with the purest lines of Homer, and with Plato's profoundest thoughts, in historic significance. The key

word of Paul's letter is *agape*—Greek for "love." The word became *caritas* in Latin. King James' translators of the Latin Bible rendered *caritas* in turn as "charity." Yet "love" appears the more appropriate word. With that substituted, the King James' text would read:

"Though I speak with the tongues of men and of angels, and have not love, I am become as a sounding brass, or a tinkling cymbal.

"And though I have the gift of prophecy, and understand all mysteries, and all knowledge; and though I have all faith, so that I could remove mountains, and have not love, I am nothing.

"And though I bestow all my goods to feed the poor, and though I give my body to be burned, and have not love, it profiteth me nothing.

"Love suffereth long, and is kind; love envieth not; love vaunteth not itself, is not puffed up.

"Doth not behave itself unseemly, seeketh not her own, is not easily provoked, thinketh no evil;

"Rejoiceth not in iniquity, but rejoiceth in the truth; Beareth all things, believeth all things, hopeth all things, endureth all things.

"Love never faileth; but whether there be prophecies, they shall fail; whether there be tongues, they shall cease; whether there be knowledge, it shall vanish away.

"For we know in part, and we prophesy in part.

"But when that which is perfect is come, then that which is in part shall be done away.

"When I was a child, I spake as a child, I understood as a child, I thought as a child: but when I became a man, I put away childish things.

"For now we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face; now I know in part; but then shall I know even as also I am known.

"And now abideth faith, hope, love, these three; but the greatest of these is love."

About the year 67 A.D., Paul met his martyrdom on the Appian Way outside Rome. In deference to his Roman citizenship he was not crucified, but beheaded. Saint Peter was crucified head-down, nearby, on the same day. Rome had struck a shrewd double blow against revolutionary religion. But it was too late, as we know. The Greeks and Jews together had already built a bridge into eternity and back again, a bridge which no temporal power ever could destroy.